

Indigenous Political Participation in Canada: Looking Beyond the Vote to Understand the Diversity of Means of Political Participation and Action.

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Abstract

In Canada, the colonial political system long curtailed the exercise of Indigenous political rights, and participation gaps between Indigenous and non-Indigenous people remain pronounced to this day. The literature, however, has dealt almost exclusively with electoral participation, eclipsing other modes of political participation. This article asks a single question: what explains the various forms of Indigenous political participation in Canada? Drawing on the five waves of the Democracy Checkup (2020–2024) — which include 1,195 Indigenous respondents — the analysis relies on ordered logistic regressions estimated by recursive blocks and structured according to the civic voluntarism model of Verba, Schlozman and Brady (1995). The results confirm the existence of an institutional-distance gradient, with the notable exception of the vote, and reveal that psychological engagement is the leading explanation of both institutional and non-institutional participation. The perception of colonial injustices, however, yields no significant effect, while the ethnocultural diversity of the social network emerges as a strong predictor of non-institutional participation — pointing to a logic of *bridging* rather than *bonding*.

Keywords: political participation, Indigenous peoples, civic voluntarism model, institutional distance, *Democracy Checkup*, Canada.

Introduction

The Canadian political system first denied, then curtailed, the political rights of members of Indigenous peoples. The wardship of status Indians from First Nations barred them from exercising the right to vote in federal elections until 1960, and in the province of Quebec until 1969 (Dubé, 2021: 26). Other constraints were placed in parallel on the exercise of the right to vote by other Indigenous peoples and communities across Canada beyond that period. And still today, Indigenous people vote far less than non-Indigenous people in Canada. Inequalities in political participation are problematic for Canadian society and for Indigenous communities alike.

Indeed, inequalities in political participation give rise to other, more consequential inequalities. When groups of citizens do not take part in the processes that select representatives or in political institutions, decision-makers hear and represent their voices less. In turn, an inequality of voice

translates into an under-representation of these groups' preferences and needs, with tangible effects on their well-being (Dahl, 1989: 95). Yet electoral participation, and institutional political participation more broadly, are not the only means of expressing one's voice in order to influence government action and one's community. Outside institutions, participation inequalities persist, but the literature on the extent of these inequalities remains limited (Berdahl et al., 2012; Estes et al., 2023; Kostelka & Scott, 2016).

The way Indigenous political participation in Canada is problematized largely places the blame on Indigenous people themselves. Yet if Indigenous people in Canada participate little in electoral processes and in Canadian political institutions, this is in part a consequence of the colonial political system. The deliberate failure to grant members of Indigenous peoples the same rights as non-Indigenous people, together with the discrimination Indigenous people faced, shows that they have held the same political rights as other Canadian citizens only recently — and that, in practice, several obstacles still hinder the exercise of those rights (Dahl, 1980: 560–561). The lack of opportunities for Indigenous people to take part in political decisions and to influence the political agenda thus provides ample reason to understand the participation inequalities they face (Dahl, 1980: 560–561).

The empirical literature on Indigenous political participation in Canada has dealt mainly with the electoral dimension, thereby eclipsing other modes of political participation (Armstrong et al., 2023; Barsh et al., 1997; Bedford & Pobihushchy, 1995; Dabin et al., 2019; Harell et al., 2009; Ie et al., 2023; Liang & Harell, 2025). The literature on Indigenous political participation therefore remains substantially limited, for want of studies that look beyond electoral participation. It would be premature to generalize participation inequalities to most modes of political participation on the basis of studies of electoral and institutional participation alone.

We therefore ask a single question: what explains the various forms of Indigenous political participation in Canada?

1. State of knowledge

1.1. The levels of Indigenous political participation in Canada

Political participation can be conceptualized along a continuum defined by the distance between a given mode of participation and formal political institutions. Van Deth (2014: 356–358) distinguishes three broad categories: institutional political participation, which falls within the sphere of government and state affairs; extra-institutional political participation, which lies outside that sphere; and community participation, which targets the concerns of the community without necessarily being organized or collective. Moving across these categories, a nuanced portrait of Indigenous participation emerges: far from amounting to a simple deficit, participation levels vary considerably with the distance separating the mode of participation from colonial political institutions.

Institutional political participation. Within institutional political participation, voting in Canadian federal elections is the most documented mode. Indigenous people participate less than non-

Indigenous voters: between 2004 and 2011, 62.35 % of Indigenous respondents reported having voted, compared with 81.75 % of all Canadian respondents (Fournier & Loewen, 2012: 21–27). In 2021, the turnout rate in Indigenous communities reached only 44.5 % in the federal election. Within Indigenous groups, internal differences persist: Inuit and Métis participate more in federal and provincial elections than members of First Nations (Fournier & Loewen, 2012: 21–27). Over time, studies show a generalized decline in electoral participation from the acquisition of the federal franchise in 1960 through the 1990s in the Maritimes, the Prairies, and Ontario (Barsh et al., 1997; Bedford & Pobihushchy, 1995: 261–262; Dalton, 2007: 270).

Participation within partisan structures constitutes a second mode directly tied to colonial institutions, and it is the one where the gap with non-Indigenous people is most pronounced. Fewer than 1 % of Indigenous people reported being members of a federal political party, against 10 % of non-Indigenous people (Harell & Panagos, 2013: 423–425). That said, this difference is likely offset in part by engagement with Indigenous cultural and political organizations: the number of Indigenous respondents who reported being involved in such organizations was similar to the number of non-Indigenous people engaged in political parties (Harell & Panagos, 2013: 424).

As for other forms of institutional participation, such as contacting a politician, Indigenous people participate in proportions similar to, or even higher than, those of non-Indigenous people. According to the 2015 National Youth Survey, 51.2 % of Indigenous youth had carried out at least one non-electoral political activity, compared with 45.5 % of non-Indigenous youth (Kostelka & Scott, 2016: 12–13). Within institutions, it appears that participation around specific issues is more important among Indigenous people.

Extra-institutional political participation. Contentious activities — signing a petition, demonstrating, erecting barricades, taking part in acts of civil disobedience — lie outside the sphere of the state and constitute extra-institutional political participation in Van Deth’s (2014: 355) sense. The literature reports a substantial increase in Indigenous contentious activity in Canada: whereas Ramos (2006) observed an average of 5 contentious events per year between 1951 and 1965, then more than 12 until 2000, Do (2023: 941–942) records an average of 40 per year between 2010 and 2020. Moreover, 76.5 % of the identified activities occurred after 2015 (Do, 2023: 941–942). At the individual level, 7.4 % of Indigenous people in northern Saskatchewan reported having demonstrated or taken part in a march in the 12 months preceding the survey (Beatty et al., 2013: 22). This level of participation is admittedly modest in absolute terms, but it belongs to an upward trajectory that contrasts sharply with the decline in electoral participation.

Community participation. It is in community participation that the portrait of Indigenous participation is reversed. In Canada, Indigenous people are involved in greater numbers in organizations linked to Indigenous identity, in youth-oriented organizations, and in recreational organizations (Harell & Panagos, 2013: 424). In identity- and culture-related organizations, Indigenous people are proportionally more involved than non-Indigenous people. The level of formal engagement in organizations is comparable between the two groups, but it is informal community participation that truly sets Indigenous people apart. Berdahl, Beatty and Poelzer (2011b: 97) find that, both on and off reserve, Indigenous respondents take part in activities such as sharing traditional meals, helping community members, and volunteering for band activities at a rate some 30 percentage

points higher. These levels of informal engagement are considerably higher than rates of institutional participation. Estes and colleagues (2023: 7–8) argue that a culturally appropriate conceptualization of community participation, one that includes informal activities, reveals a much richer register of participation than traditional indicators suggest — a reminder that it is incumbent upon researchers to include modes of political participation that are meaningful to Indigenous people.

The institutional-distance gradient. Synthesizing these findings brings to light a participation gradient that we may call the institutional-distance gradient. Indigenous participation is lowest in modes directly tied to colonial political institutions — voting and partisan engagement — rises in extra-institutional modes such as demonstrating and contentious action, and reaches its highest levels in community participation. The participation gap with non-Indigenous people follows a similar trajectory: it is most pronounced for electoral and partisan participation, narrows — or even reverses — for extra-institutional activities, and widens in favour of Indigenous people in community participation (Harell & Panagos, 2013; Berdahl et al., 2011b; Kostelka & Scott, 2016). This pattern is consistent with the idea that the perceived distance between Canadian political institutions and Indigenous communities structures participation: the further a mode of participation is from colonial structures, the more Indigenous people take part in it.

1.2. The explanatory factors of Indigenous political participation

We organize the explanatory factors of Indigenous political participation according to the three blocks of Verba, Scholzman and Brady’s (1995) civic voluntarism model. This theoretical model posits that political participation is a function of the resources individuals possess, of their psychological engagement with politics, and of the recruitment processes that prompt them to participate. This structure makes it possible to examine systematically how each block of factors contributes to explaining Indigenous political participation across the different modes of participation.

Resources: age, education, and income. The first block of the civic voluntarism model gathers the individual resources that facilitate political participation. Civic skills — which we measure through age — education, and income constitute the three main components of this block, and the literature shows that their influence is especially decisive for institutional modes of participation.

Age is the most robust factor in explaining Indigenous electoral participation. Across all the national contexts surveyed, older age positively influences the propensity to vote. In Canada this effect is particularly pronounced: the propensity to vote rises by 0.194 to 0.297 percentage points for each additional year (Berdahl et al., 2012: 35; Fournier & Loewen, 2012: 31). Age is also the most discriminating factor between Indigenous and non-Indigenous people: its effect on the probability of voting is one point higher among Indigenous people (Harell et al., 2009: 18). This asymmetry is amplified by demographic structure: Indigenous youth, who vote less, are proportionally far more numerous in the Indigenous population in Canada (Fournier & Loewen, 2012). By contrast, for modes of participation more distant from institutions, the influence of age diminishes or reverses: people aged 30 to 50 are more likely to demonstrate (Harell et al., 2009: 21), whereas age negatively influences the community volunteering of off-community Indigenous people (Berdahl et al., 2011b: 98).

Education exerts a positive influence on all modes of participation, but its effect on electoral participation is generally weaker than that of age in Canada (Berdahl et al., 2012: 35; Henderson, 2004: 148). For extra-institutional and community participation, education remains influential: Indigenous people with postsecondary studies are 1.22 times more likely to demonstrate and take part in 27.5 % more community activities (Harell et al., 2009: 21; Berdahl et al., 2011b: 98; Estes et al., 2023: 9, 22). Education operates not only as a direct resource but also as a vehicle of socialization: the political discussions that emerge at university make Indigenous youth more inclined to vote (Silver et al., 2005: 27), while the school curriculum develops attitudes and skills transferable to community participation (Walsh et al., 2019: 198–199).

Income contributes positively to electoral participation, with an estimated effect of between 0.09 and 0.17 percentage points in Canadian federal elections (Fournier & Loewen, 2012: 31; Henderson, 2004: 146). This factor is more discriminating for Indigenous people than for non-Indigenous people: the effect of income on electoral participation is 9 percentage points for the former, against 4 points for the latter (Fournier & Loewen, 2012: 31). However, income acts differently depending on the mode of participation: it lowers the propensity to demonstrate, low-income Indigenous people being 1.12 times more likely to take part in demonstrations (Harell et al., 2009: 21–22). This reversal suggests that material resources are more closely associated with institutional modes of participation.

On the whole, resources structure Indigenous participation in a differentiated manner according to institutional distance: their influence is strongest for modes directly tied to institutions (voting, partisan engagement) and diminishes for extra-institutional and community modes, where other mechanisms take over.

Psychological engagement: political interest, efficacy, and partisan identity. The second block of the civic voluntarism model brings together the attitudes and psychological dispositions that motivate individuals to participate. Interest in politics, political information, the sense of political efficacy, and partisan identity constitute the main components of this block.

Interest in politics positively influences participation in elections across all the contexts studied (Berdahl et al., 2012: 35; Fournier & Loewen, 2012: 31). Interest is also a significant predictor of other modes of participation among Indigenous youth (Kostelka & Scott, 2016; Mahéo & Vissers, 2015).

Political and electoral information is a factor whose influence is particularly marked: Indigenous people who follow the news have a probability of voting that is 16 percentage points higher (Howe & Bedford, 2009: 33). The crucial lack of electoral information, underscored in several interviews (Silver et al., 2005: 22–23), constitutes a distinctive obstacle for Indigenous people. Civic duty, an attitude often instilled by the family, ranks among the most important predictors of electoral participation: the probability of voting rises by 27 points when Indigenous people conceive of voting as a duty (Fournier & Loewen, 2012: 31).

In sum, psychological engagement plays a cross-cutting role in explaining Indigenous participation. The nature of the relevant attitudes nonetheless varies with the mode of participation: for voting, political and electoral information is decisive, whereas for modes more distant from colonial

institutions, political interest takes over. This differentiation suggests that psychological engagement gains in relative importance for modes of participation more distant from institutions, but that the very nature of the psychological dispositions mobilized is transformed.

Recruitment: social networks, political discussion, and mobilization. The third block of the civic voluntarism model concerns the mechanisms through which individuals are solicited to participate. Family, peers, the community, organizations, and political parties constitute the main recruitment agents identified in the literature.

The family is the first agent of political socialization and mobilization for Indigenous people. The family setting has been identified as the place where the civic habits and attitudes necessary for participation are developed, notably with respect to voting and standing as a candidate (Silver et al., 2005: 24–25). As for peers, their mobilization has a positive impact on both electoral participation and volunteering: when most of a voter’s friends are also registered to vote, the probability of voting rises by 0.72 points (Bergh et al., 2018: 278–279; Kostelka & Scott, 2016: 28–29).

The community plays a recruitment role that goes beyond mere socialization. The cultural and political environment specific to each community influences Indigenous people’s political behaviour in a distinctive way. Several Indigenous respondents state that their community integration motivates them to vote in Canadian elections in order to protect their culture and rights (Silver et al., 2005: 20–22). Organizations constitute another important recruitment network: individuals engaged in organizations are 1.7 times more likely to vote in federal elections (Harell et al., 2009: 21–23), and the founding of new Indigenous organizations brings about an increase in the number of contentious actions (Ramos, 2006: 225).

Finally, political parties and electoral institutions play a recruitment role, albeit a more limited one. The presence of Indigenous candidates raised the turnout rate by nearly 6 percentage points in territorial Indigenous communities in the federal elections following the *Idle No More* movement (Dabin et al., 2019: 47). Several interview participants stated that the presence of candidates and campaign teams in Indigenous communities is beneficial for sharing information, sparking interest, and encouraging participation (Silver et al., 2005: 34; Hrabik et al., 2024: 7). Political parties and electoral institutions nonetheless remain less influential than family and community networks in explaining Indigenous participation, particularly that of Indigenous youth (Kostelka & Scott, 2016: 28–29).

Recruitment thus operates through proximity networks — family, peers, community — that appear especially salient for community modes of participation, whereas institutional agents — parties, electoral organizations — exert a more marked influence on electoral and partisan participation. The literature suggests that mobilization through proximity networks transcends modes of participation, which could explain why the recruitment block contributes to explaining Indigenous political participation in a relatively constant manner across the institutional-distance continuum.

1.3. Synthesis and foundations of the hypotheses

The review of the literature brings two structuring observations to light. First, Indigenous political participation in Canada cannot be reduced to a generalized deficit: it is better understood as a

realignment of modes of participation according to distance from colonial political institutions. Indigenous people participate least in modes directly tied to colonial political institutions and most in non-institutional modes, which leads us to think that Indigenous political participation is organized according to its distance from formal political institutions (H1).

H1: The *further* political action takes place from political institutions, the *more* the level of Indigenous political participation *increases*.

Second, the explanatory factors of participation operate differently depending on whether the mode of participation lies *within* political institutions or *outside* them. It is expected that **resources** — age, education, income — exert a preponderant influence on institutional participation and a lesser one on non-institutional participation (H2a). In parallel, it is expected that **psychological engagement** exerts a greater influence on non-institutional than on institutional participation (H2b). In short, the explanation of Indigenous political participation should shift from resource factors toward psychological-engagement factors when political participation lies *outside* Canadian political institutions.

H2a: Resources have a greater effect on the institutional participation of Indigenous people than on their non-institutional participation.

H2b: Psychological engagement has a *greater* effect on the non-institutional participation of Indigenous people than on their institutional participation.

It is expected that agreeing that yesterday's and today's colonialist policies harm the social and economic well-being of Indigenous peoples will have a negative influence on institutional participation and a positive influence on non-institutional participation. Because this statement constructs the Canadian government and political system as a historical obstacle to the well-being of Indigenous peoples, the dissatisfaction and cynicism channelled in it should be reflected in lower participation in Canadian political institutions and a greater presence in more claim-making modes of participation.

H3a: Agreeing that “a long history of colonialist policies harms the social and economic well-being of Indigenous peoples” is associated with a lower level of institutional participation among Indigenous people.

H3b: Agreeing that “a long history of colonialist policies harms the social and economic well-being of Indigenous peoples” is associated with a *higher* level of *non-institutional participation* among Indigenous people.

Conversely, both institutional and non-institutional Indigenous political participation should be positively associated with a statement underscoring the Canadian government's failures to give Indigenous peoples their fair share. The reason is that such a statement implies a demand addressed to the government that may signal a motivation to influence the selection of political decision-makers as well as the implementation of public policy.

H4: Agreeing that “Indigenous peoples have received less from the government than

they deserve” is associated with a *higher* level of *institutional* and *non-institutional* participation among Indigenous people.

The recruitment of Indigenous people within their social networks also remains under-studied, with priority having been given to resources and psychological engagement. By focusing on the characteristics of informal social networks, we put forward three additional hypotheses. Drawing on a social-capital approach, it is expected that the association between the ethnocultural diversity of Indigenous people and institutional participation will be positive. Since people with an ethnocultural identity other than Indigenous will likely be non-Indigenous — and the latter tend to participate more — Indigenous people with a more diverse social network should be more exposed to people who are more likely to vote, which could mobilize them to vote and to engage with partisan institutions. Conversely, lower ethnocultural diversity should be associated with a higher level of non-institutional participation. *Bonding* social capital is distinguished by a propensity to turn inward toward one’s community. It would therefore be plausible that a higher frequency of social interactions within one’s community increases non-institutional political participation.

H5a: *Greater ethnocultural diversity* within one’s social network is associated with a *higher* level of institutional participation among Indigenous people.

H5b: *Lower ethnocultural diversity* within the social network is associated with a *higher* level of non-institutional participation among Indigenous people.

It is expected that two other recruitment factors — the size of the social network and the frequency of political discussions — are positively associated with both institutional and non-institutional participation. Social networks transmit political information, apply norms, and convey requests to participate politically. People who benefit from more information and more requests to participate should therefore participate more. Likewise, the political value of social networks — that is, the frequency of political discussions — should convey all the more political information, norms, and requests to participate as social interactions intensify.

H6: A *larger social network* and a *higher frequency of political discussions* are both associated with a *higher* level of *institutional* and *non-institutional* participation among Indigenous people.

2. Methodology

The analyses rest on the pooling of the five waves of the Democracy Checkup (2020–2024), an annual cross-sectional survey administered to a representative sample of the adult Canadian population. The cross-sectional structure brings the total number of observations to 42,054, of whom 1,195 identify as Indigenous. Statistical inference focuses on the Indigenous respondents, to the exclusion of residents of the Territories (an *n* too small to yield stable estimates) and of the residual “Other” category. All data processing and analyses were carried out in R, drawing principally on the *tidyverse*, *MASS* (Venables & Ripley, 2002), *sandwich* (Zeileis, 2004: 4–6), *lmtest*, and *flextable* ecosystems.

Operationalization of the dependent variables. Following Van Deth’s (2014) conceptual map-

ping and the organization by modes of Verba, Schlozman and Brady (1995), the eight political-participation indicators available in the Democracy Checkup were grouped according to a gradient of distance from colonial political institutions: one electoral mode (voting in the last federal election), three partisan modes (party membership, party donation, and party volunteering), two extra-institutional modes (signing a petition, taking part in a demonstration), and two community modes (donating to a charity and volunteering for an organization). For the regression analyses, these eight binary modes were aggregated into two count variables contrasted over the same number of trials: institutional participation (0–4 = vote and three partisan modes) and non-institutional participation (0–4 = two extra-institutional and two community modes). This specification with an identical number of trials preserves the comparability of coefficients from one dependent variable to the other.

Descriptive analyses. The first stage characterizes the structure of political participation within the Indigenous subsample by comparing the participation rates observed across the four modes (electoral, partisan, extra-institutional, and community). This descriptive characterization serves to assess the institutional-distance gradient posited in H1.

Regression analyses by recursive blocks. The second stage models the two count variables by means of ordered logistic regressions (the proportional-odds model; Long, 1997). Because the dependent variables range from 0 to 4 ordered participation modes, an ordered logit is more appropriate than a binomial specification: each coefficient is reported as an odds ratio (OR) expressing the multiplicative factor applied to the odds of being in a higher participation category for a one-unit increase in the independent variable. Ordinal independent variables were treated as numeric in order to obtain a single coefficient per variable and to favour parsimony (Long, 1997). The Prairies (province) and English as a mother tongue (language) serve as reference categories, in keeping with their weight in the Canadian literature on Indigenous political behaviour (Harell, Panagos & Matthews, 2009: 18, 25); the year 2020 and “Man” (gender) are the remaining reference categories. Robust (HC1-type) standard errors were computed to guard against the misspecification of the error variance.

Estimation follows a cumulative-block strategy inspired by the structure of the civic voluntarism model (Verba, Schlozman & Brady, 1995: 269–272, 276–279), which orders determinants into resources, psychological engagement, and recruitment. Two nested specifications anchor the analysis. The **complete model** introduces four blocks in succession: (1) sociodemographic controls (survey year, gender, province, language), (2) resources (age, education, income), (3) psychological engagement (political interest, internal efficacy, external efficacy, strength of partisan identification), and (4) recruitment (frequency of political discussions, social network size, and social network diversity). This complete model is estimated on the full Indigenous subsample ($N = 1,120$ for institutional participation and 1,119 for non-institutional participation). The **reduced model** inserts, between the psychological-engagement and recruitment blocks, a fifth block of two indicators of colonial issue engagement (a historical dimension and a redistributive dimension), bringing the total to five blocks. Because these issue-engagement items carry more missing values, simultaneous listwise deletion across all analysis variables reduces the sample to $N = 811$ (institutional) and 810 (non-institutional). The label “reduced” therefore refers to the reduced number of observations, not to a smaller set of predictors. Listwise deletion within each model ensures an identical

N across the nested models being compared, a validity condition for fit comparisons.

The incremental contribution of each block is assessed through a likelihood-ratio test between nested models (Long, 1997), complemented by examination of McFadden’s (1974) pseudo- R^2 and of its block-by-block increment (Δ pseudo- R^2).

3. Results

This section reports the findings of the regression analyses. It addresses the research question — what explains the various forms of Indigenous political participation in Canada? — by characterizing the participation gradient and then testing the application of the civic voluntarism model, augmented by a block dedicated to colonial issues. The reported coefficients are odds ratios from ordered logistic regressions estimated by recursive blocks, with robust (HC1) standard errors in parentheses. Following each finding, its substantive interpretation is taken up in the Discussion.

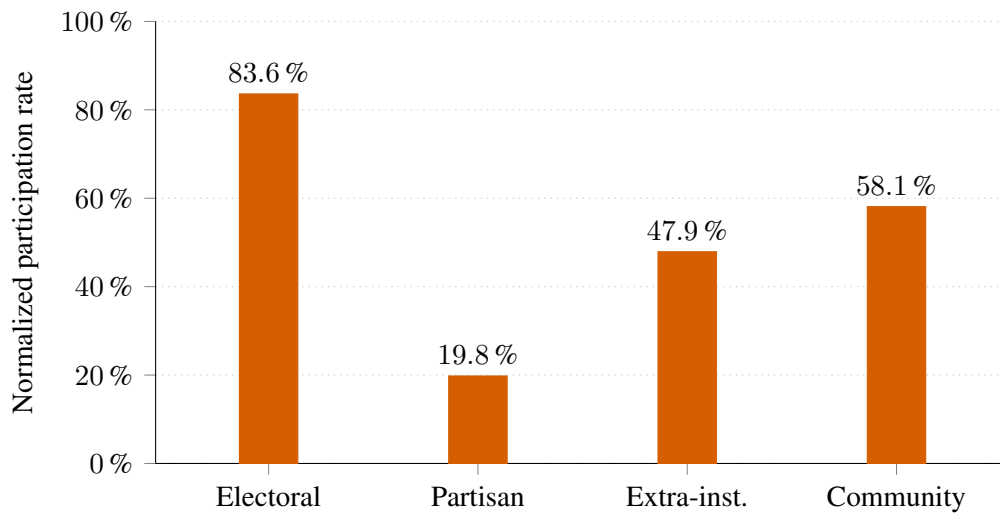


Figure 1: Political participation rates across the four types — Indigenous respondents

The institutional-distance gradient (H1). The descriptive analysis partially disconfirms H1. Contrary to the theoretical expectation, electoral participation is the most practised mode among Indigenous respondents (83.6 %), exceeding all other types. The remaining three types nonetheless follow the expected increasing order: partisan participation is the most marginal (19.8 %), followed by extra-institutional participation (47.9 %) and community participation (58.1 %). The vote thus stands out as an exception within an otherwise coherent ordering: setting voting aside, the sequence fully respects the hypothesized institutional-distance gradient.

Resources (H2a). The analyses confirm H2a. Each of the three resource factors — age, education, and income — is positively and significantly associated with institutional participation, and this association is stronger, or marginally stronger, than the corresponding association with non-institutional participation (Table 1). The incremental contribution of the resource block reinforces this conclusion: the Δ McFadden pseudo- R^2 reaches 0.025 for institutional participation (Model 1A) but only 0.007 for non-institutional participation (Model 6A).

Table 1: Ordered logistic regression by recursive blocks explaining the institutional (Model 1A) and non-institutional (Model 6A) participation of Indigenous people from the civic voluntarism resources (odds ratios with standard errors and significance)

Variable	Model 1A (Inst.)	Model 6A (Non-inst.)
<i>Sociodemographic controls</i>		
Woman (ref. Man)	0.71 (0.12)**	1.38 (0.11)**
Allophone (ref. Anglophone)	1.01 (0.34)	0.91 (0.33)
Francophone (ref. Anglophone)	1.50 (0.22) [†]	0.99 (0.20)
<i>Resources</i>		
Age	1.02 (0.00)***	1.00 (0.00)
Education	1.51 (0.09)***	1.35 (0.08)***
Income	1.18 (0.06)**	1.09 (0.05)
McFadden pseudo- R^2	0.039	0.016
Δ McFadden pseudo- R^2	0.025	0.007
N	1,120	1,119

Note. Ordered logistic regression on a 0–4 scale of participation modes carried out in the past 12 months. Institutional participation: voting, party membership, volunteering for a candidate or party, and donating to a candidate or party. Non-institutional participation: taking part in a demonstration, march or rally, signing a petition, volunteering for an organization, and donating to a charity. Each cell reports the odds ratio (robust standard error in parentheses). Significance: [†] $p < 0.10$; * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$. *Controls.* All models include fixed effects for survey wave (ref. 2020) and province of residence (ref. Prairies). These rows are omitted from Tables 1–4 to streamline presentation; the full coefficients are reported in Table 5 (Appendix).

Psychological engagement (H2b). The analyses disconfirm H2b. Contrary to expectations, the four psychological-engagement factors have a larger effect on the institutional than on the non-institutional participation of Indigenous people: each displays an at least marginally stronger association with institutional participation (Table 2). Only political interest and the strength of partisan identification maintain a strong and significant association with both types of participation. The incremental contribution of the psychological-engagement block is nearly twice as large for institutional participation (Δ McFadden pseudo- $R^2 = 0.051$) as for non-institutional participation (0.026).

Table 2: Ordered logistic regression by recursive blocks explaining the institutional (Model 2A) and non-institutional (Model 7A) participation of Indigenous people from civic voluntarism psychological engagement (odds ratios with standard errors and significance)

Variable	Model 2A (Inst.)	Model 7A (Non-inst.)
<i>Sociodemographic controls</i>		
Woman (ref. Man)	0.88 (0.12)	1.79 (0.12)***
Allophone (ref. Anglophone)	1.33 (0.34)	1.16 (0.33)
Francophone (ref. Anglophone)	1.61 (0.22)*	1.00 (0.20)
<i>Resources</i>		
Age	1.02 (0.00)***	0.99 (0.00)*
Education	1.41 (0.09)***	1.26 (0.08)**
Income	1.11 (0.06) [†]	1.02 (0.05)
<i>Psychological engagement</i>		
Political interest	1.77 (0.09)***	1.73 (0.08)***
Internal political efficacy	1.11 (0.07)	1.06 (0.06)
External political efficacy	1.02 (0.07)	0.92 (0.06)
Strength of partisan identification	1.58 (0.06)***	1.23 (0.05)***
McFadden pseudo- R^2	0.090	0.042
Δ McFadden pseudo- R^2	0.051	0.026
N	1,120	1,119

Note. Ordered logistic regression on a 0–4 scale of participation modes carried out in the past 12 months (see Table 1 for the modes). Each cell reports the odds ratio (robust standard error in parentheses). Significance: [†] $p < 0.10$; * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

Colonial issue engagement (H3a, H3b, H4). The analyses offer limited support for H3a and disconfirm H3b and H4 (Table 3). The historical-dimension variable maintains a weak, negative association with institutional participation (consistent with H3a), but the coefficient does not reach statistical significance; the same variable is also weakly and negatively associated with non-institutional participation, contrary to the positive effect predicted by H3b. The redistributive-dimension variable at the heart of H4 is weakly negatively associated with institutional participation — against the prediction — and weakly positively associated with non-institutional participation, but neither estimate is significant. The block’s incremental contribution is null to negative (Δ McFadden pseudo- $R^2 = -0.004$ for institutional and -0.001 for non-institutional participation).

Table 3: Ordered logistic regression by recursive blocks explaining the institutional (Model 3) and non-institutional (Model 8) participation of Indigenous people, including colonial issue engagement (odds ratios with standard errors and significance)

Variable	Model 3 (Inst.)	Model 8 (Non-inst.)
<i>Sociodemographic controls</i>		
Woman (ref. Man)	1.00 (0.15)	1.75 (0.14)***
Allophone (ref. Anglophone)	1.54 (0.41)	1.18 (0.41)
Francophone (ref. Anglophone)	1.52 (0.27)	1.03 (0.25)
<i>Resources</i>		
Age	1.02 (0.00)***	0.99 (0.00)
Education	1.35 (0.10)**	1.30 (0.10)**
Income	1.10 (0.07)	1.08 (0.06)
<i>Psychological engagement</i>		
Political interest	1.72 (0.10)***	1.65 (0.09)***
Internal political efficacy	1.15 (0.08) [†]	1.07 (0.08)
External political efficacy	1.02 (0.08)	0.92 (0.07)
Strength of partisan identification	1.53 (0.07)***	1.18 (0.06)**
<i>Issue engagement</i>		
Colonial political issues — historical	0.89 (0.12)	0.97 (0.11)
Colonial political issues — redistribution	0.95 (0.11)	1.01 (0.10)
McFadden pseudo- R^2	0.086	0.041
Δ McFadden pseudo- R^2	-0.004	-0.001
N	811	810

Note. Ordered logistic regression on a 0–4 scale of participation modes carried out in the past 12 months (see Table 1 for the modes). Reference category for the colonial-issue variables: “Disagree”. Each cell reports the odds ratio (robust standard error in parentheses). Significance: [†] $p < 0.10$; * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

Social-network diversity (H5a, H5b). The analyses confirm H5a, though only tentatively. Ethno-cultural network diversity maintains a positive and moderate association with institutional participation, but this association is not significant in Model 4 (Table 4). The analyses largely disconfirm H5b: rather than the predicted negative association, network diversity is strongly, positively, and highly significantly associated with non-institutional participation (Model 9), an association whose magnitude rivals that of political interest.

Network size and political discussion (H6). The analyses offer mixed support for H6. Social network size maintains a negative association with both types of participation, but this association is weak and statistically non-significant. The frequency of political discussions, by contrast, is positively, strongly, and highly significantly associated with both institutional and non-institutional participation (Table 4).

Summary. Taken together, these results paint a differentiated picture of Indigenous political participation. The institutional-distance gradient structures participation levels, with the notable exception of the vote, which remains the dominant mode. Within the civic voluntarism model, psychological engagement weighs more heavily than either resources or recruitment, without a clear specialization emerging by mode of participation. The colonial block, added to capture a specific political experience, yields no significant individual effect in these estimates. Several results — chief among them the positive effect of network diversity on non-institutional participation (H5b) — invite a theoretical reinterpretation in terms of *bridging* rather than *bonding*.

4. Discussion

The vote as an exception. The persistence of the vote as the dominant mode of participation runs against the institutional-distance gradient and calls for explanation. Part of the answer likely lies in the composition of the sample. The Democracy Checkup is administered online to the Léger Opinion panel, which raises two concerns about the representativeness of the Indigenous subsample. First, Indigenous populations living in remote settings have less frequent access to an internet connection; an online survey therefore under-represents respondents whose propensity to vote is lower and over-represents urban residents. Second, members of an opinion panel display a higher propensity to vote, since the habit of answering surveys to express one's preferences is closely tied to the habit of voting (Holbrook & Krosnick, 2010: 58–59). These two sources of bias would, however, hardly suffice to halve the electoral participation rate without also affecting — even marginally — the other types of participation. The result thus indicates that the vote remains the privileged mode through which Indigenous people make their voice heard within colonial political institutions, notably to protect collective interests and treaty rights (Belanger, 2009: 37–38; Harell et al., 2009; Silver et al., 2005: 27–28).

Realignment rather than deficit. The confirmation of H2a — resources weigh more heavily on institutional than on non-institutional participation — has a direct implication: the literature on Indigenous electoral participation, founded precisely on the preponderant role of resources, cannot be generalized to other modes of participation. What that literature documents is less a global deficit than a realignment of participatory repertoires. Indigenous people mobilize different registers depending on whether the mode of participation approaches or moves away from colonial

Table 4: Ordered logistic regression by recursive blocks explaining the institutional (Model 4) and non-institutional (Model 9) participation of Indigenous people from civic voluntarism mobilization (odds ratios with standard errors and significance)

Variable	Model 4 (Inst.)	Model 9 (Non-inst.)
<i>Sociodemographic controls</i>		
Woman (ref. Man)	0.99 (0.15)	1.78 (0.14) ^{***}
Allophone (ref. Anglophone)	1.42 (0.41)	0.96 (0.40)
Francophone (ref. Anglophone)	1.59 (0.27) [†]	1.07 (0.26)
<i>Resources</i>		
Age	1.02 (0.00) ^{***}	1.00 (0.00)
Education	1.35 (0.10) ^{**}	1.26 (0.10) [*]
Income	1.06 (0.07)	1.05 (0.07)
<i>Psychological engagement</i>		
Political interest	1.50 (0.11) ^{***}	1.41 (0.10) ^{***}
Internal political efficacy	1.12 (0.08)	1.02 (0.08)
External political efficacy	1.01 (0.08)	0.89 (0.07)
Strength of partisan identification	1.50 (0.07) ^{***}	1.16 (0.06) [*]
<i>Issue engagement</i>		
Colonial political issues — historical	0.90 (0.12)	0.98 (0.11)
Colonial political issues — redistribution	0.93 (0.11)	0.95 (0.10)
<i>Mobilization</i>		
Frequency of political discussions	1.35 (0.10) ^{**}	1.38 (0.09) ^{***}
Social network size	0.94 (0.10)	0.91 (0.09)
Social network diversity	1.15 (0.09)	1.51 (0.09) ^{***}
McFadden pseudo- R^2	0.092	0.058
Δ McFadden pseudo- R^2	0.006	0.017
N	811	810

Note. Ordered logistic regression on a 0–4 scale of participation modes carried out in the past 12 months (see Table 1 for the modes). Each cell reports the odds ratio (robust standard error in parentheses). Significance: [†] $p < 0.10$; ^{*} $p < 0.05$; ^{**} $p < 0.01$; ^{***} $p < 0.001$.

institutions, and the factors that drive them to do so shift accordingly (Berdahl et al., 2012: 35; Estes et al., 2023).

The centrality of psychological engagement. The absence of a specialization of psychological engagement by mode of participation (H2b unsupported) runs against the intuition drawn from the civic voluntarism model. Verba, Schlozman and Brady (1995) hold that psychological engagement is more decisive in the presence of partisan infrastructures that mobilize, which should advantage institutional modes; the literature on Indigenous participation shows, by contrast, that it is resources that predominate there, possibly indicating a lack of mobilization by political parties (Belanger, 2009). Even though its contribution is smaller, in both absolute and relative terms, for non-institutional participation, this does not call into question the centrality of psychological engagement: political interest remains the single most important factor across both types of participation. If the hypothesis is rejected, it is ultimately because the civic voluntarism model works less well for non-institutional than for institutional participation. A methodological limit nonetheless frames this finding: aggregating institutional and non-institutional modes ignores the distinction among modes of participation according to the temporal resources they require (Verba et al., 1995). Time-intensive modes are grouped with modes that are not, which blurs intra-block comparisons.

An instrument limit for the colonial block. The inconclusive results for H3a, H3b, and H4 do not point to a non-existent relationship but to a limit of operationalization. Four factors likely intersect. First, the effect of a strong interest in government policy may remain imperceptible in dependent variables that stay general, aggregating four distinct modes of participation (Verba et al., 1995: 393). Second, the size of the Indigenous sample may hamper the detection of a weak association between issues and participation — a difficulty Verba and colleagues themselves noted, the association between interest in government policy and the participation index being far weaker than associations with variables such as political interest (Verba et al., 1995: 395). Third, and most importantly, the survey items measure *agreement* with a statement rather than the *salience* of that issue in the decision to participate; two respondents who agree equally may differ radically in the weight they place on the issue, and only salience may be mobilizing. Finally, the Democracy Checkup attitude module is designed to measure respondents' resentment toward other population groups, which may make it ill-suited to a conceptualization of issue engagement: more than 70 % of Indigenous respondents agree with the statements, leaving too little variance to produce estimable effects.

The inoperability of the bonding/bridging distinction. The dual positive association of ethnocultural diversity with both modes of participation (H5a confirmed, H5b contradicted) is best read through a logic of *bridging* rather than *bonding*. For institutional modes — voting and engaging within party institutions — a network comprising more individuals who do not share an Indigenous identity favours Indigenous participation, a result consistent with the notion of bridging social capital: ties to members of other communities, ethnocultural or geographic, expose individuals to norms and values associated with higher participation (Putnam, 2000: 22–24). For non-institutional participation, the strength of the diversity effect probably reflects a limit of measurement: the survey does not specify the *type* of organization in which the individual is embedded. The distinction between an Indigenous community organization — anchored in ethnocultural solidarity, a bonding logic — and a non-ethnicized civic organization — outward-looking, a bridging

logic — is thereby inoperable (Harell & Panagos, 2013; Estes et al., 2023). Since the majority of Indigenous respondents likely come from urban settings, the activities and organizations they join probably gather participants on bases other than ethnocultural identity, which could explain why a diversified network is so strongly and positively associated with non-institutional participation (Putnam, 2000: 20–22).

The political value of networks rather than their size. The contrast between the null effect of network size and the strong effect of the frequency of political discussions (H6) indicates that it is the conversational, political quality of the network — not its sheer size — that mobilizes. This finding reinforces the idea that not all forms of social capital are equal: what is overtly political in social interactions counts far more than the social norms applied during apolitical interactions (McClurg, 2003: 459–460). It also prolongs the observation made about H2b on the centrality of psychological engagement: if political discussion is counted among the expressions of such engagement, it is the active relationship to politics, rather than the sociodemographic conditions of exposure, that structures Indigenous participation.

Conclusion

This study set out to explain the various forms of Indigenous political participation in Canada. The pooling of the five waves of the *Democracy Checkup* (2020–2024), analyzed through ordered logistic regressions estimated by recursive blocks, yields a clear answer.

The results confirm that we must move beyond a reading in terms of deficit to adopt one of a *realignment* of participatory repertoires. Resources structure institutional participation, but their explanatory power erodes for non-institutional participation, where recruitment through networks — and especially the political value of those networks — takes over. Psychological engagement, expected to be a specific driver of out-of-institution modes, proves instead to be a cross-cutting factor and remains the central explanation of participation across both modes. The colonial block, in so far as we operationalized it, yields no significant individual effect; its limits appear to stem from the instrument rather than from the absence of any relationship. Finally, the strong positive association between the ethnocultural diversity of the social network and non-institutional participation invites a reinterpretation in terms of *bridging* rather than *bonding*, and calls for closer examination of the channels through which the colonial experience bears on Indigenous political participation.

Appendix

Table 5: Complete recursive-block models of the institutional (Model 5A) and non-institutional (Model 10A) participation of Indigenous people (odds ratios with standard errors and significance)

Variable	Model 5A (Inst.)	Model 10A (Non-inst.)
<i>Sociodemographic controls</i>		
2021 (ref. 2020)	0.99 (0.21)	1.06 (0.20)
2022 (ref. 2020)	1.13 (0.20)	0.84 (0.19)
2023 (ref. 2020)	0.92 (0.20)	0.62 (0.19)*
2024 (ref. 2020)	1.06 (0.21)	0.70 (0.19) [†]
Woman (ref. Man)	0.87 (0.12)	1.82 (0.12)***
British Columbia (ref. Prairies)	1.06 (0.18)	1.16 (0.17)
Maritimes (ref. Prairies)	0.71 (0.21)	1.01 (0.20)
Ontario (ref. Prairies)	0.77 (0.15) [†]	0.85 (0.14)
Quebec (ref. Prairies)	0.89 (0.27)	1.48 (0.25)
Allophone (ref. Anglophone)	1.23 (0.35)	0.92 (0.33)
Francophone (ref. Anglophone)	1.65 (0.22)*	0.99 (0.20)
<i>Resources</i>		
Age	1.02 (0.00)***	0.99 (0.00) [†]
Education	1.40 (0.09)***	1.24 (0.08)**
Income	1.08 (0.06)	0.99 (0.06)
<i>Psychological engagement</i>		
Political interest	1.55 (0.10)***	1.51 (0.09)***
Internal political efficacy	1.08 (0.07)	1.02 (0.06)
External political efficacy	1.01 (0.07)	0.89 (0.06) [†]
Strength of partisan identification	1.55 (0.06)***	1.20 (0.05)***
<i>Mobilization</i>		
Frequency of political discussions	1.31 (0.08)***	1.30 (0.07)***
Social network size	1.03 (0.09)	1.06 (0.08)
Social network diversity	1.06 (0.07)	1.37 (0.07)***
McFadden pseudo- R^2	0.095	0.056
Δ McFadden pseudo- R^2	0.005	0.014
N	1,120	1,119

Note. Complete model (four blocks) estimated on the full Indigenous subsample; the colonial issue-engagement block is excluded, which preserves the larger N . Ordered logistic regression on a 0–4 scale of participation modes carried out in the past 12 months (see Table 1 for the modes). Each cell reports the odds ratio (robust standard error in parentheses). Significance: [†] $p < 0.10$; * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

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